from Lahore with the addition of their eastern territories, until their demise in the second decade of the thirteenth century. The Mongol campaigns of the 1220s CE compelled Juzjani to take refuge in Delhi, where he completed *Tabaqat* sometime before his death in 1260 CE.[24] But beyond this ontogenetic resonance between author and subject, *Tabaqat* also presents rare insights: throughout the work, subtle but discernible indices emerge of Juzjani grappling with the tensions between the "historiographic expectations" of twelfth-century Persian historical writing, and his own vested interests in crafting his patrons' memorial power for posterity. What we learn from these tensions, and the fissures between expectations and "reality," will be discussed later in the chapter and throughout this volume.

Attaining Kingship: Perso-Islamic Cultures of Power

The historical overview of the early Shansabanis in the latter part of this chapter reveals the *lacunae* that persist in our knowledge of their activities, even after the marshalling of evidence from material–cultural sources such as numismatics and architectural patronage. But while the *minutiae* of the Shansabanis' rise to regional and then transregional ascendancy may not be fully perceivable, tracing even its broad contours presents the opportunity to reflect on the Persianate ecumene specifically during the twelfth century. This temporally focused analytical gaze on the admittedly *longue durée* historical phenomenon of the Persianate permits, I believe, an enrichment of its more punctual manifestations.

At variance with recent reconsiderations of the concept of the "Persianate" – introduced by M. Hodgson in the last quarter of the twentieth century – I propose that, for the place and time of our investigation, "Perso-Islamic" is a more apt descriptive term for the elite cultures discussed forthwith.[25] Furthermore, rather than conceiving of these cultures of power, or prestige cultures, as *in*accessible except to those already within their ambit – that is, elites begetting elites – we must concede that courts throughout central and western Eurasia were often established by newcomers to the Persianate cultural world. What made this possible?

In attempting to answer such a broad question, I do not aim to define per se Perso-Islamic cultures of power, as they differed in their details at each court according to myriad historical contingencies (see, e.g., Chapter 3). Instead, it is more productive to adopt an inverted approach: what aspects of these prestige cultures facilitated access to kingship for ambitious interlopers such as the Shansabanis? Taking a cross-section of the twelfth century, and particularly the intersecting imperial formations of the Ghaznavids, the Saljuqs, and, eventually, the Shansabanis in what is now Afghanistan (map, p. xv), we can propose some tentative answers